3.2 The Election of 1876

With our 24/7 online news feed, it can be hard to focus on one important problem when other issues arise. But this also happened in the 1870s, when scandals and economic woes distracted Americans from Reconstruction.

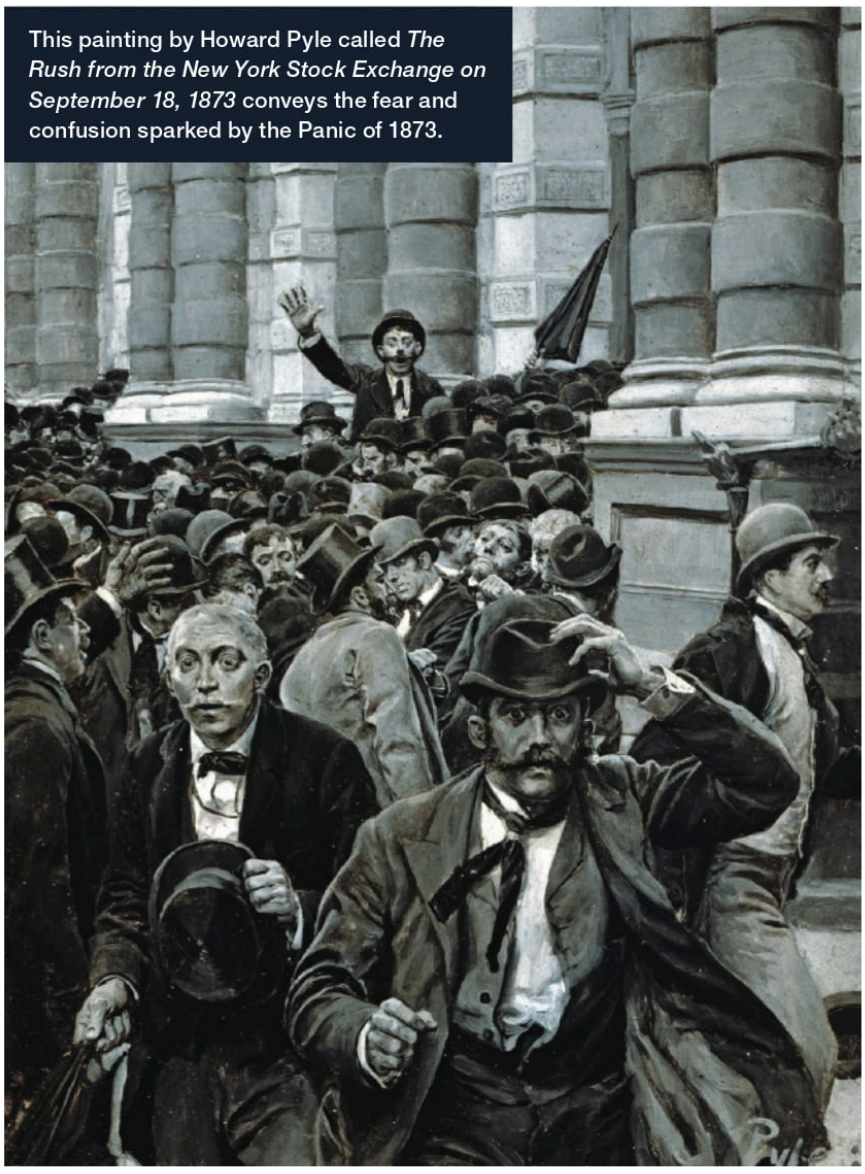
MAIN IDEA As scandals and a depression arose, a compromise reached over a contested election brought Reconstruction to an end.

SCANDAL AND PANIC

Ulysses S. Grant had been an effective general, but he proved to be a poor administrator. He often relied on Congress to make the types of decisions he should have made as the country's leader. He also was unable to keep his party from splintering into different factions, or groups, each promoting a different political viewpoint. The **Liberal Republicans** were among these factions. They believed the government had become too large and too powerful. They favored free trade and an end to Reconstruction. In American politics of the 1870s, the word *liberal* referred to someone who embraced these ideas.

Leading up to the election of 1872, the Liberal Republicans **defected**, or broke away, from the Republican Party and formed an alliance with Democrats. They nominated Horace Greeley, a newspaper editor from New York City, as the Democratic presidential candidate. Greeley's main goal was to end Reconstruction, but that was not enough to appeal to voters. Grant easily won re-election.

But accounts of dishonest behavior plagued Grant's second term. These scandals involved **bribery**, or offers of money or privileges in exchange for political favors. Financial wrongdoing among legislators and Cabinet members surfaced. For instance, Congress investigated Secretary of War William Belknap for **corruption**, another word for dishonesty. Congress accused Belknap of accepting cash gifts from army suppliers, which led to his resignation.



This painting by Howard Pyle called *The Rush from the New York Stock Exchange on September 18, 1873* conveys the fear and confusion sparked by the Panic of 1873.

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The Election of 1876

Hayes (Republican)

Uncontested Electoral: 165 votes

Electoral Vote: 185 votes, 50.1%

Popular Vote: 4,034,311 votes, 48.5%

Tilden (Democrat)

Uncontested Electoral: 184 votes

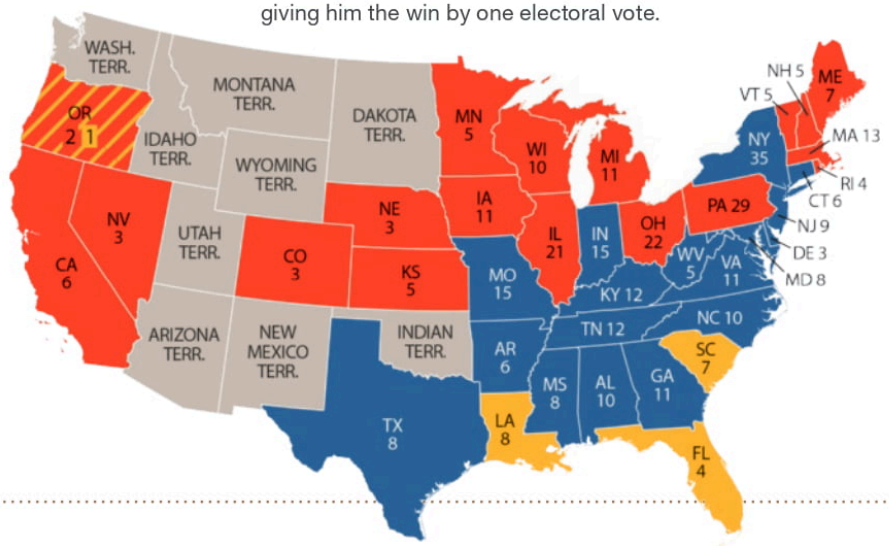
Electoral Vote: 184 votes, 49.9%

Popular Vote: 4,288,546 votes, 51.5%

Territories, No Returns

Contested Electoral Votes

Twenty electoral votes from Florida, Louisiana, Oregon, and South Carolina were contested, or disputed, following charges of voter fraud. The controversial election was finally settled by the Compromise of 1877. All 20 votes went to Hayes, giving him the win by one electoral vote.



To make matters worse, economic disaster struck in 1873 when bank and railroad failures triggered an economic crisis called the **Panic of 1873**. Many people lost their money when banks closed and lost their jobs when businesses collapsed. As unemployment rose, the country slid into a depression that lasted six years.

END OF RECONSTRUCTION

As the depression wore on, economic concerns overshadowed the nation's interest in Reconstruction. In 1876, two court cases dealt a further blow to the cause of African Americans' civil rights. The U.S. Supreme Court ruled in *U.S.* v. *Cruikshank* that the civil rights amendments only allowed the federal government to prevent states from abusing African Americans' civil rights. The job of punishing individuals fell to the states. In *U.S.* v. *Reese,* the Court ruled that the 15th Amendment only made it illegal to deny a person the right to vote based on race. States could use other criteria, such as **literacy tests**, or tests of one's ability to read and write, to exclude voters.

By the 1876 presidential election, Democrats had regained control of several southern states and the U.S. House of Representatives. Democrats nominated Samuel J. Tilden as their candidate. The Republican nominee was **Rutherford B. Hayes**. The race was extremely close, with election results in several states disputed. Congress created an electoral commission to decide the election, but while it met, Democrats and Republicans got together to negotiate a deal. In what came to be called the **Compromise of 1877**, Democrats agreed to award the victory to Hayes if Republicans agreed to end Reconstruction and pull federal troops out of the South. The deal was struck.

In the end, Reconstruction fell short of its goals. It had raised and then dashed hopes that African Americans would achieve equality. To some degree, African Americans made advances. But to help African Americans overcome the effects of hundreds of years of slavery and racism entirely would have required a great expansion of federal power. Still, although the promise of the 13th, 14th, and 15th amendments remained unfulfilled during Reconstruction, these amendments became the legal basis for the civil rights movement of the 1960s.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What views did Liberal Republicans promote?
2. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** What impact did the 1872 Amnesty Act, the 1876 election, and the withdrawal of federal troops from the South have on civil rights for African Americans?
3. **INTERPRET MAPS** How many contested electoral votes did Tilden need to win the election?

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